

Peak Performance

A tricky, little-known mountain nestled in Kazakhstan is smaller than Mt. Everest but as challenging. The first foreigners to scale it happen to be Indian army men.



THE VICTORIOUS TEAM SHOWS OFF ITS FLAGS

| By Sandeep Unnithan |

When Lieutenant-Colonel Saurabh Singh Shekhawat, 37, spotted the black, snow-capped heights of Marble Wall peak in Kazakhstan, he thought conquering it would be a breeze. Named for its white marble deposits, the 6,400-m mountain is dwarfed by the 8,848-m high Everest which the young officer has climbed three times. Yet, it would be his toughest climb ever. The challenge lay in the unpredictable weather and summiting the mountain through a climb window of less than 12 hours (Everest has a five-day window). In terms of climbing difficulty, Marble Wall is between grade 6 and grade 8 as compared to Everest's grade 7 and K2's grade 9. As the leader of a joint Indo-Kazakh army expedition, Shekhawat was to promote military diplomacy with the strategically located central Asian country through joint mountain climbs. Shekhawat's six-member team joined 12 Kazakh climbers for the expedition in late August.

The team chose the Alpine climbing style—few ropes and gruelling climbs—over the Indian Army's 'siege method' of setting up camps and extensive use of ropes.

The expedition in the former Soviet republic would have none of the luxuries now available for Everest. The summit bid was greeted by a blizzard which brought visibility to under a metre, winds of over 110 kmph and the mercury at minus 35 degrees. The expedition turned back. Czech, German and Russian teams had already called off their climbs due to adverse weather.

Two days later, in the window suggested by the National Centre for Medium Range Weather Forecasting, Delhi, the group began its ascent again, conscious that one false step by a single member could hurtle everybody to an icy death. Eight hours later, the expedition summited the peak, becoming the first foreign team to scale this remote mountain in the Tien Shan range. But as mountaineers say, the proof of the pudding is in the descent. The Indians got detached from the Kazakhs and lost their way in howling winds. They made it back to the base camp by sheer instinct, winning the appreciation of their tough Kazakh comrades. Shekhawat recalls: "We had to persist because it was the reputation of two nations and two armies." ■